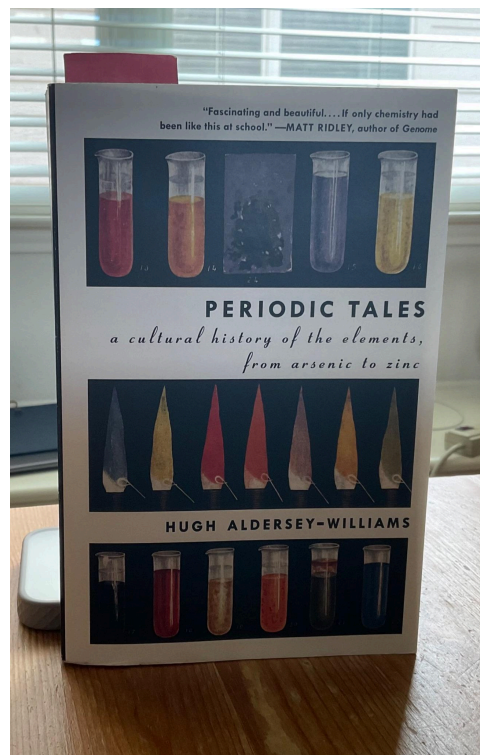


Periodic Tales Review

Back in June I was window shopping at Half Priced Books and found a few (non-fiction) titles that caught my eye. Fast forward to Labor Day weekend and I found the perfect opportunity to sit down and grind out the remaining pages (about 200 pages or so).

For some background, I've actually read Theodore Gray's (Grey's?) Periodic Table and Molecules book so when I started reading this book I was more interested in the discovery and lore of the elements over the elements themselves. With that perspective my TL;DR is: *If you enjoyed Gray's books then I recommend the first half of the book. If you haven't read the book or you aren't super into elements I think it's a skip.*



The Review

The book itself is sorta structured based on chronological discovery of elements/foundational concepts. For example, Gold is covered immediately while Neodymium only appears in the last half after Uranium and Aluminum. What this means is the narrative slowly shifts from historical accounts of the element itself into commentary of its uses in the modern day (of 2009). While there's nothing inherently wrong with that, it did change how invested I was in the book since I found that the second half had a lot more personal tangents and stories. In addition there was a noticeable increase in art interpretations as we got into newer elements like Chrome, Niobium, and Titanium which furthered my disinterest. Of course there were a few artworks that struck out to me like Walter Benjamin's *Angel*, Alexander Calder's *Mercury Fountain*, and Joseph Wright's *The Alchymist** but it comes to a point where I want to focus on the pioneers, inventors, and egos involved with the specific elements. The history of how Tin and Aluminum fell from royal grace, the story of how Mendeleev really liked making leather suitcases, the culture surrounding precious metals - these are the kind of stories I was initially signed up for and are what I'll talk about (at least the ones I personally found interesting).

Some of the highlights I personally enjoyed are listed below:

- The discovery of Phosphorus

- Noble Gases including Mendeleev's reaction and the doubling down of the scientists who initially discovered Helium
- Mendeleev apparently liked making leather suitcases in his free time
- [The Pale Horse](#) by Agatha Christie popularized Thallium poisoning (both in diagnosis and usage)
- Ezekiel chapters in the Bible sound way cooler than I would've EVER imagined and I only learned this during the sulphur (brimstone) section.
- I knew Platinum was lumped in with Rhodium, Iridium, and Osmium but I didn't know the discovery was split between two folks and turned into a rivalry
- Occultum. It's something alright.

* In case you were wondering my literal notes on each were:

- *Angel* was too relatable
- *Mercury Fountain* was cool because it served a physical representation of the Cinnabar mine strikes at the time and a cultural representation of how non-chalant people were with touching pure mercury
- *The Alchemist* "no way they made the piss collector aura farm"

And then the notes I wrote up for the sections of the book I liked:

- The discovery of phosphorus (the piss collector), the controversy of noble gases (Mendeleev definitely ate a few leatherworks in anger), the awareness of Thallium poisoning, the biblical connotations of sulphur, the two business people Wallston and Tennant 1v1ing over I think platinum, and the psychic channeling occultum LMFAOOO.

Anyways the 1 year anniversary of my first blog post is coming up so I'll likely prepare something for that (it WILL be OldSchool RuneScape focused).